officials] and to send these to Lucknow,' explained the local party official. 'Our IT Cell is sitting there. A group of 300–400 people is sitting there. They work like a call centre. Daily they pick a place and their work is to make checks like this: like today they pick Mathura, tomorrow it will be Agra and so on.'[26]

This system of real-time monitoring was one of the new tech/data-enabled management systems introduced in UP from 2014 onwards. The membership drive was accompanied by centralised data-collection as well as a reshuffling of the party's organisation.

The Importance of the 'Small' Man: A New 'Chair' for Booth Presidents

The BJP's internal reordering was based on a simple organising idea: that the voting booth is at the heart of winning elections. This thesis became the endpoint of all organisational work. When BJP leaders speak of strengthening the foundations of the party, it is the booth level they focus on. Because the lowest grassroots unit of any Indian election process is the voting booth, the BJP has centred much of its structural shift and reorganisation since 2014 on the logistical aspect of getting voters to these booths.

Narendra Modi illustrated this point when speaking to the party's women leaders in Karnataka in May 2018: 'For me, this is the most important thing. And that is to win the polling booth. If we win the polling booth, then no power in the world can defeat us in the assembly election. So, where does victory reside? It resides in the polling booth. Everything else is the impact of that. We have to win the polling booth and the fight has to be fought there.'[27]

This last-mile focus on mobilising the voter at the booth level has driven the expansion-drive strategy in many states. In Karnataka, N. Ravi Kumar, the party general secretary for the state and MLC, summed up this approach to me in early 2020: 'Ten years back, nobody cared about booth-level workers in the party. They only cared about MLAs, MPs or zila panchayat presidents. Now a booth-level president is important in our structure.'[28]